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Some Myths About Bias: A Queer Studies Reading of Gender Bias in NLP

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Drawing from concepts in Queer Theory, this project critiques NLP methods that perpetuate two "myths" about gender bias:

1. **Bias is Categorical (bias is present/absent)**
2. **Bias is Zero-Sum (equalization = fairness)**

These assumptions flatten complex bias types and categories into reductive and ineffective metrics that attempt to "neutralize" or "equalize" bias. Rather than approach bias as a thing to be reduced or eliminated through neutrality or equalitzation, this project proposes methods that harness gender as a flexible and multiply expressive binary system (see below).

QUEER STUDIES AS A METHODOLOGICAL LENS

From Queer Theory:

Judith Butler's concept of the "**necessary outside**" of binary systems—what is excluded in order to stabilize categories like male/female (*Bodies That Matter*, 1993).

Eve Sedgwick's point that binary oppositions are not symmetrical, but structured by **"simultaneous subsumption and exclusion"** (*Epistemology of the Closet*, 1990).

Jack Halberstam's concept of binaries create a **"gender relay"** system which can produce nonconforming identities that resist fixed categories (*Female Masculinity*, 1998).

To NLP methods:

NLP systems—by encoding these binaries—reproduce and reinforce representational harms by failing to acknowledge or model what falls outside of them.

NLP's bias metrics can mask underlying hierarchies that are inherent to binary pairs, for example in bachelor/spinster [Devinney et al, 2023].

A way forward for amplifying—rather than eliminating—typically gendered terminology (e.g., using "the pretty doctor" to expand representational potential) [Stanovsky et al., 2019].

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